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12-Step Program To High-End PR

Dealing With the Real Media

The Twittersphere, blogosphere, and world of Facebookery are relevant and trendy ways to attract attention and attendance to your mosod and peulos, but they don't come close to the credibility provided by high-quality coverage on real media platforms. National newspapers and community gazettes alike dictate what is important to their target audiences, creating relevance, importance, and pride related to your mosod and those associated with you.

Besides providing the opportunity to make more connections, credible media coverage is often a shliach's best reference when meeting new people. A memorable newspaper article reads better than a polished profile, and an impressive radio interview definitely speaks louder than a glittering sales pitch.

But...it has to be done right. If good publicity is good, bad publicity is, well, you get the picture. Here are some guidelines to maximize and accentuate the benefits of your PR.

Before You Start

Prior to writing any article, you should cover some background bases to drive your media initiative home. This little bit of proper planning is more than worth your effort.

1 Purpose Ask yourself, what do I want to accomplish by getting publicity? Awareness of an important issue? Attendance to an event? General visibility of my Chabad House? Once you've determined your purpose, it's time to think about your...

2 Target Audience Whose attention do I want to attract? National Jewish media? Local general media? Anash? Secular? Choose an outlet that will attract attention from those whose attention you seek, and make sure your story is relevant to such an audience. It would be more than futile to send a social report to a business publication....

3 Angle It is important to note that not every event is newsworthy. Do not approach the media with events that would be deemed to be of mediocre interest to them. However, bear in mind that although the event might not be newsworthy on its own, it might have a newsworthy angle. For example: a community newspaper will be interested in a dignitary or celebrity attending your event. Ensure every story is something you yourself would be interested in reading.

4 Advertorial When compiling an advertisement, consider requesting an advertorial. This will allow you more words and often does not appear to readers as an advertisement.

FROM SOCIAL MEDIA TO REAL MEDIA

In December of 2009 and January of 2010, a phenomenon was sweeping through nonprofit organizations all across America. For those who were able to drum up the support of more Facebook fans than any other small nonprofit, Chase Bank was handing out money and lots of it.

A teen volunteer decided that it was time to put money in the Friendship Circle coffers. Using his Twitter account, he contacted the host of national television's daily aired *The Morning Show*.

To his amazement and joy, the host was willing to have Friendship Circle volunteers on the show to explain to viewers how to vote for the Friendship Circle on Facebook.

It was a perfect example of social media gaining credibility and support because of the real media.

The Friendship Circle eventually finished in fourth place with nearly 60,000 votes, earning them \$100,000. However, with the conventional pool of voters depleted, it was the crossroads where social and real media met that garnered their massive support.

The success of that campaign came down to the hard work of many individuals and groups, but the real media in the form of national television definitely played its part.

5 Support Displaying your support with a paid advertisement or the like is not only a great form of appreciation but also adds credibility to your mosod.

Writing and Distribution

Now that you have a clear vision, follow these steps to get your PR properly produced.

Want to try your hand at writing a press release?

Our sample should give you a good idea of what one should look like.

PG67 BY SHANA GUZICK, *Compass Editor*

6 Delegating If writing or distributing your PR falls outside the scope of your expertise, it is important to delegate to someone who is competent and reliable. It might be worth paying a higher price for professional services, rather than settling for a cheaper amateur product. Remember, the quality of what you publish represents the quality of your mosod.

7 Editing Even though most publications will proofread an independently written piece, it is still crucial to ensure that the grammar and spelling are correct in any piece you submit. It is unnecessary additional work for publications to deal with a "dirty" copy, which will likely be thrown out instead of corrected. And even if they do publish a poorly edited piece, is that the face you want to show to the public?

8 Timing Submit your article or publication (or invite the press to an event) with a *minimum* of two weeks notice, and follow up with confirmation - not as if you are checking if they are attending, but for security, seating, and catering arrangements.

9 Sources Do not let your PR piece emanate from too many sources. Find a competent contact in your media platform of choice, and allow all your dealings to go through that source only. This person is rarely an editor; many people report more sympathy from senior journalists, yet each case will obviously be case specific.

After Sending It Off

Sent your polished PR to all the right places? Don't get comfortable so fast; the job's not quite over.

10 Follow Up It is important to clarify that your piece reached the hands of the relevant people. It is, however, not worth your while to pester the intended source. Media coverage is a privilege, not a right. Should the media agree to publicize and/or attend your event, contact relevant people beforehand. Give them a courtesy call, or better yet, invite them to an unrelated breakfast or lunch. Besides the fact that everyone loves to eat and drink, it also gives you the opportunity to promote yourself and the angles you would like to be reported in a relaxed manner. If the press is coming to your event, designate someone who is capable of highlighting necessary aspects of your event to the press.

11 Hakoras HaTov Make sure you thank those who helped you if you get good media coverage. This can definitely make a positive impression and gain you favor for your next PR piece.

Preventing Unpleasant PR *You're Not Alone*

Sometimes things happen that can be less than positive for your Chabad House's reputation. Bad news travels quickly, but often, a simple (and timely) clarification is all you need to prevent, chas v'sholem, a chilul Hashem. Contact Rabbi Motti Seligson at the Chabad-Lubavitch Media Center if you need help.

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AS SIMPLE AS PLANNING AHEAD

Rabbi Michael Goldin of Teaneck, New Jersey learned that sometimes media coverage can come about by something as simple as forward planning.

Having completed his year's schedule for his CTeen and youth-group events, Rabbi Goldin ensured that a copy of the calendar reached the hands of the local staff journalist at the *NJ Record*.

With the forewarning, the writer was able to find events that she thought would be of interest to her readership. The writer posted an article regarding Chabad of Teaneck's youth-group trip to the local police station to do acts of kindness.

The success of the coverage was twofold. Parents already associated with the youth programs and the Chabad House were thrilled to see their children in the local paper. The happiness of the parents translated into better participation in further programs. More importantly, it attracted parents (and, therefore, youth) from otherwise uncharted areas that were not reached by word of mouth, advertising, or social media.



PHOTO: RICK MALKIN

Rabbi Yitzchok Teichtel of Nashville, TN presents a live pre-Pesach kosher cooking demonstration on News Channel 5.

12 **Let People Know** Should your contact be fruitful, make sure to let the relevant press people know of your success, and let your community know you're famous!

If this seems like a lot, keep in mind that the first steps in setting up a good rapport with the media will always be the most difficult ones. Trial and error are the best teachers, and it'll only get easier with experience. You won't regret the effort!

Written by Rabbi Dovber Chaiton

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Press Release How-To

1 Your title should be short, catchy, and relevant. Keep it under ten words (under seven, even better).

2 All of the important details (who, what, where, when, and why) need to come in the first one to two sentences.

3 Your second paragraph is the place to elaborate a little more about the details of the event. Keep paragraphs 1-2 sentences each.

4 Quotations need to be interesting and informative. "We are really excited for this event" won't cut it.

5 Don't leave 'em hanging! Always end with a way to reach you for more info.

6 This indicates the end of the text for the press release itself.

7 Mention that your event is a great photo op – even if they don't publish your article, they might still want photos of your event – which can be just as strong (or stronger) PR.

Are you sure you know how to use a semicolon? If you're not, don't use one. Consult a professional.

FOR IMMEDIATE RELEASE:

1 A MATZA-BAKING EVENT NOT TO BE PASSED OVER

2 Springfield, NY – March 12, 2012 – In preparation for the upcoming Jewish holiday of Passover, Chabad of Springfield will be hosting an authentic matza-baking factory Sunday March 25 at the Springfield Mall at 1:30 P.M., where attendees will take part in a full-blown Passover experience.

3 The factory will take participants through the entire matza-baking process, from grinding the flour, to making the dough, to puncturing the dough with the small holes that give matza its characteristically flat and crunchy texture, all the way to baking – and eating! – this home-made Passover treat.

The holiday of Passover marks the Jews' exodus from their bondage in Egypt and their subsequent pilgrimage to freedom in the land of Israel. But...what's the connection to the flatbread? When the Jews left Egypt, bringing their dough with them for sustenance along the journey, they left in such haste that the dough did not have time to rise. Instead, it became matza, "the bread of affliction."

"What does a Jewish kid in New York have to do with a slave in Egypt more than 3,300 years ago?" asks Rabbi Mendel Horowitz of the Chabad of Springfield. "This event is meant to bridge the disconnect between the original Passover of 1313 BCE and the modern Passover of 2012," he explains. "A hands-on, five-senses kind of experience is better education than any synagogue pamphlet or Hebrew-school class."

Today, Jews the world over celebrate Passover, taking place this year from April 6-April 14, in part by eating matza and staying away from the leavened stuff for eight days.

4 "While eating matza is important," Rabbi Horowitz explains, "we can't forget that the meaning of Passover is so much more than that – it's a proclamation of our faith, unity, and rights." He continues, "We are so blessed as Jews in the new millennium to be celebrating our freedom in public; that's the true sign that the miracle of Passover lives on to this very day."

5 Chabad of Springfield regularly hosts Jewish cultural events and informative courses on a variety of Judaic subjects, as well as Shabbat and holiday meals and prayer services. For more information, contact Rabbi Mendel Horowitz at rabbimendel@springfieldchabad.org or 718-770-5772.

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7 Media Notice: The event is open to reporters and photographers, and coverage is invited. Rabbi Mendel Horowitz will be available to answer questions.

Good to keep in mind:

Ninety percent of readers won't read past the first three paragraphs of any article.

Press releases and news pieces are structured with the most important information first, and the least important information at the end. That way, the editor can cut a piece wherever necessary, while still maintaining the most crucial information.

Every paragraph should offer a new piece of information. Don't merely restate what's said somewhere else.

Do a word count. If your press release is more than 500 words, it's too long! 🚫